

Chapter 62-1

Liang Shi stood in place for a long time, unable to move.

The wind blew from all directions, yet she felt an indescribable warmth.

Tears soaked through her shirt, falling on her skin, scalding hot, spreading all the way to her heart.

She opened her mouth wanting to speak, but couldn't utter a single word.

This emotion was too complex.

It had been a long time since she'd experienced such feelings.

It was as if an impenetrable wall had cracked open at this moment, and water flowed unrestrained through the fissure.

Flowing through her limbs and bones, leaving her entire being at a loss for what to do.

All the grievances she had endured before, the bitterness and pain she suffered when leaving that world, seemed to have found an outlet for release at this moment.

Those baseless curses, those insults that cut to the bone, those people who denied her efforts and her very existence.

She had worked so hard to avoid seeing those things, knowing that unplugging the internet would make it all irrelevant.

But those comments had destroyed her faith and ruined her dreams.

She considered herself to have never done anything wrong to anyone, yet those people didn't spare her despite her clear conscience.

Instead, they came at her like ocean waves, beating her to death on the shore, pulling her into the tide.

She was powerless to resist.

Yet had no choice but to accept it.

Sister Wang¹ had once told her that in this profession, one must endure what ordinary people cannot endure, and bear what ordinary people cannot bear.

If you can't handle others' curses, then quit early.

So she had accepted being cursed as part of the job.

But she had also wondered quietly in the depths of night—are criticism and cursing the same thing?

Bad acting can be criticized, but why curse?

Was it because they were truly angry, or just to vent their emotions?

After countless times of denying herself, she picked up her confidence countless times again.

She made herself into what she was now, able to pretend not to care while doing this job, reading others' comments, whether good or bad.

Even after reading them, she could still comfort Xu Qingzhu.

She had made herself impenetrable.

But now, it seemed like someone cared about her.

Someone empathized with everything she had suffered, someone would worry about her being subjected to those curses and insults, so they advised her not to step into that circle anymore.

Liang Shi's heart was filled with mixed emotions, and her eyes had also reddened from the wind.

After a long while, she wrapped one arm around Xu Qingzhu in return, still smiling as she comforted, "It's okay, everything will pass."

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Xu Qingzhu also knew she had lost composure and closed her eyes on the way back, pretending to doze.

Liang Shi didn't expose her either, driving the car all the way back to Shallow Water Bay.

The online public opinion was still fermenting. Xu Qingzhu went to Chen Liuying's Weibo comments section for a stroll and discovered that Chen Liuying had already closed her Weibo comments.

Bai Weiwei's was the same.

But all netizens were still cursing while trending hashtags, presumably receiving many private messages as well.

When Liang Shi brought her hot milk, she found Xu Qingzhu looking at this and asked, "Does it make you sad?"

"For whom?" Xu Qingzhu put her phone on the bed, took the milk and gently sipped it. Her lips were stained with a layer of white, and she stuck out her tongue tip to lick it off, then asked in return, "Bai Weiwei?"

Liang Shi nodded.

After all, they had once been good friends.

"Not really." Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly, then quickly relaxed, "Perhaps everyone is selfish. When she chose to confront me online, all the affection between us was gone. I can't feel sorry for her."

She said "can't," not "don't feel sorry."

Liang Shi noticed the difference in that single word and raised an eyebrow, "Can't?"

"That's right, can't." Xu Qingzhu said, "Feeling sorry for her would mean denying all of your efforts today. I can only say that people must pay the price for their actions, so there's nothing to feel sorry about."

Liang Shi nodded, "Very true."

Xu Qingzhu held the glass cup with both hands, and after a while, shifted the topic to tonight's incident, "Teacher Liang, just pretend I never said that."

"Said what?" Liang Shi didn't react for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, "About asking you not to enter the entertainment industry."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I just feel like public figures seem to have to accept too many things." Xu Qingzhu said, "Those things make people... very unhappy."

"I know." Liang Shi smiled slightly. She stood in the doorway, the dim light casting a halo around her face, "So, thank you."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled, "Thank me for what?"

"Nothing." Liang Shi felt too embarrassed to pierce through that layer of pretense. Once said, both would be awkward, and there was no need.

"Go to sleep early." Liang Shi reminded her.

Xu Qingzhu's clear eyes stared at her, and only when she was about to leave did she say, "Liang Shi, if you see those unhappy things in the future, you can also talk to me about them."

Liang Shi originally wanted to politely decline, but when she met the sincerity in those eyes, her words took a turn, and she said gently, "Okay."

¹ Sister Wang (王姐) - A respectful way to address an older woman colleague or mentor, particularly common in professional settings in China

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Because she had seen so many curses, Liang Shi had a rather unpleasant dream that night.

Perhaps it wasn't even a dream.

To her, it was just a very distant past.

When she was a newcomer just emerging in the entertainment industry, she didn't have many fans. There was a female actress of the same type who felt threatened, so she made subtle digs at her on Weibo.

Then those netizens rushed to her Weibo to curse her.

And later, after the drama she collaborated on with Sun Chengcheng ended, she clearly hadn't done anything. Even during the promotional period, she deliberately avoided Sun Chengcheng.

Yet she was still cursed.

They cursed her sexual orientation, her preferences, cursed her for being scheming and setting up a persona.

Those things were like dark clouds, pressing down on her heavily, raining down on her.

But someone stood beside her, holding up an umbrella.

After Liang Shi woke up, she instinctively reached to touch the person beside her, but suddenly remembered this was the bed downstairs, and Xu Qingzhu wasn't beside her.

This was the first time since moving out of that room that she had the instinctive action of reaching to touch the person next to her.

But in the dream, she had indeed seen Xu Qingzhu.

She held up that umbrella and said to her, "Let's walk together."

So they strolled in the pouring rain, and the fierce wind couldn't break their figures.

Liang Shi sat on the bed and took a heavy breath, then lay back down looking at the ceiling.

Last night's scene had indeed given her quite a shock.

Many times she could actually hold on by herself, because she was used to supporting herself alone.

But when someone starts to care about you, that instant can make a person become very fragile.

She used great effort to restrain her tears and those emotions of grievance that grew wildly like spring vines.

In front of Xu Qingzhu, there was no need for that.

The little princess felt wronged and empathized to that extent just from seeing so many comments. How could she add more knives to the little princess's heart?

So, as always.

Let the past be the past.

Liang Shi had always been relatively open-minded.

However, her heart felt warm, and even going to work had motivation.

Just as she was about to get up, that familiar mechanical voice rang out again:

【Ding dong! Congratulations to the host for accumulating 80 luck points and successfully unlocking the usage rights of this body. What a cause for celebration! You really are the most gifted host I've ever seen! This deserves applause (clap clap clap).】

【At the same time, the host has unlocked dual side missions: 1. Take a three-day, two-night trip with Xu Qingzhu. I hear that during travel, it's easiest to get close to each other's hearts. You can set up tents together, stay in the same room, see the ocean, high mountains, and desert, admiring sunrise and sunset together. Mission deadline is October 31st—there's really plenty of time to complete it! Mission reward: 3 luck points or 300,000 RMB.

Friendly reminder: After 80 luck points, it will become a ten-tier broadcast and release side missions. The difficulty of accumulating luck points afterward will double, so please weigh your options carefully, host.】

【Side Mission 2: Go to an orphanage/nursing home with Xu Qingzhu. In such places that spread love, it's easier for people to feel the host's charm. Please grasp this opportunity well, host. This mission deadline is next Sunday at 24:00. You can choose to give up within 24 hours before the mission ends. Giving up won't deduct luck points or accumulate bad luck points (whisper: the bad luck system will be offline for 30 days). If you don't choose to give up, it will be considered that the host is confident in completing the mission. Mission overdue will deduct 2 luck points. Mission reward: 50,000 RMB, which will be transferred to the host's account within ten minutes after mission completion.】

【PS: The dual side missions were added based on the host's financial requirements. The host can choose to accept one or multiple missions. Once side mission one is accepted, it must be completed. Failure to complete will deduct ten luck points. Please choose carefully, host.】

【PS again: Unlocking the usage rights of this body doesn't mean the host has the right to freely view the original body's memories. Due to the original body's own closed nature, the Grudge Management Bureau will only transmit the information currently available to you. Please check to receive it.】

【PS again again: Host, if you choose not to have your body transported over, the Grudge Management Bureau will terminate the binding with you at this time. You will become a free person in this world, but from then on, the Grudge Management Bureau will never come online again, which means—you won't have another chance.】

【PS again again again: Wuwuwu¹, host, you must think clearly. Do you really want to abandon little system?】

【Mission broadcast complete. Please choose to accept missions quickly, host. Work hard to complete them after accepting!】

This time the system had more missions than before, and they were optional.

Liang Shi hadn't expected to obtain 80 luck points in such a short time. She had thought it would take three months to reach 80, and not dying would be good enough.

After all, her opening was too much of a hell mode.

But fortunately, her target was beautiful and kind-hearted.

It should be that yesterday's public relations crisis gave Xu Qingzhu a new understanding of her, so her favorability toward her went UP.

It directly pulled it to 80.

It could also be because Xu Qingzhu's sympathy was at work, feeling that she had lived too miserably before, so her favorability went UP.

Regardless of the reason, Liang Shi had now unlocked the usage rights of this body, which was a cause for celebration.

She didn't have to die.

But...

¹ Wuwuwu (嗚嗚嗚) - An onomatopoeia representing crying or whimpering sounds, commonly used in Chinese internet slang to express sadness or being upset

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"What exactly is the 'Happy Home' you mentioned before?" Liang Shi suddenly asked in a heavy voice. "If my luck points accumulate to 100, you'll transport my body over and erase all traces of my existence in that world. But what about the original body? Where will she go? Will she be locked up?"

The system fell silent.

A few seconds later, the system said: 【The Grudge Management Bureau has an interstellar prison. She will spend the rest of her life there.】

"But we've also switched before." Liang Shi said, "If I once existed in this world, then she also existed in that world. Why not let us switch back? Why must she be locked in an interstellar prison?"

System: 【The grudge value accumulated on her body is too heavy. If she continues to be released back, she will endanger society, and your previous exchange was itself a mistake. She got a very good opportunity but didn't cherish it. Instead, she became a grudge aggregation. Her resentment is now at the level of a 3S-grade perverted murderer.】

"But you haven't tried to understand why she became like this, have you?" Liang Shi said, then paused. "According to the evidence I currently have, she was sent to be a wealthy family's pet, and was used as a sacrificial offering. She suffers from bipolar disorder, sex addiction, and may have also suffered abuse. You can't demand that a person who has been severely harmed continue to be a kind person, right? That's too harsh."

The system instinctively said: 【But aren't you exactly that?】

"What do you mean?" Liang Shi frowned. "Who has severely harmed me?"

The system fell into a strange silence again, and after a moment shifted the topic: 【If she gradually calms her resentment in the interstellar prison and restores the grudge value on her body to a normal level, we will grant her a new identity and release her into the world where she should be.】

"Is it here?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【Sorry host, this is classified information and cannot be disclosed.】

"Is there really no other way?" Liang Shi continued to ask. "If I choose to stay in this world, can't she return to the original world? Also, how many people in the interstellar prison can calm their grudges down?"

System: 【...】

After a long time, the system answered: 【None.】

Liang Shi: "..."

Then what's the point of saying all that?

These people are already full of resentment, and you put them in a place like a prison. How could they possibly calm down?

Pure fantasy.

Liang Shi was helpless. "Is there really no other way? Like washing away her memories and letting her start over?"

System: 【..You're making things difficult for me.】

Liang Shi: "I'm just fighting for an opportunity for everyone. I came here which is equivalent to taking her place, and I just happen to discover that her badness isn't innate but because she suffered abuse. So why can't she have a chance to start over? You're being too arbitrary."

System: 【...So I say you're still too kind.】

Liang Shi: "??"

After a moment, the system said: 【The original owner's soul contains too many vile genes. Her greed, selfishness, and violent temper baseline are far higher than normal people, so...】

The system paused, that strange mechanical voice said: 【Her fate is already determined.】

Liang Shi knew this meant there was no room for negotiation. She accepted both side missions.

At the same time, the system also reminded her that she still had one additional mission she hadn't done, which meant she now had three missions on her hands.

...The pressure was immense.

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At the same time, at the Liang family's old mansion.

After finishing dinner, Qiu Zimin turned on the TV, only to find a drama about finding lost relatives playing.

She only glanced at it before turning it off.

Her heart felt blocked.

So she went online again to search for the previous Dongling City abduction case. The online discussion about that matter had already decreased.

That large-scale abduction case from twenty years ago had come to a close, and many people had found their lost children.

But Qiu Zimin had searched secretly for a long time and still hadn't found her daughter.

Watching those people online reuniting with their lost relatives, her heart felt uncomfortable.

Father Liang came over after finishing his meal. Seeing her eyes brimming with tears, he immediately knew what she was thinking about and said gently, "Don't worry, we'll find her."

Qiu Zimin sighed. Just as she was about to speak, Father Liang's phone rang.

She had no choice but to continue watching.

Father Liang answered, and a few seconds later suddenly said, "You found a lead on my daughter?"
